

## All about me

- BORN: 50
- DIED: 121
- NATIONALITY: Chinese
- FACTOID: I was an official in the court of Emperor He of Han.
- IN A NUTSHELL: Born in Guiyang (modern-day Leiyang), China, I was made an official in charge of manufacturing instruments and weapons.

# Cai Lun

The man who mashed up tree bark, created PAPER, and changed the world of writing



### A little heavy reading

Before the invention of paper, reading was a heavyweight pastime. Civilizations, such as the Mesopotamians, wrote on heavy **clay tablets**. In China, books were made of **bamboo**, which wasn't very flexible, or from very expensive silk. In the West at that time, people were still making notes on wax tablets and using papyrus or **ANIMAL SKINS** to write on.



Paper is still made in much the same way today.

By the way... the Europeans wrote on parchment, which was made from the skins of baby animals.

Paper didn't get to Europe until the 12th century

### A barking idea

In 105, Cai invented paper. He took the soft inner bark of a **mulberry tree**, added bamboo fibers, and mixed in some water. He **GAVE THE MIXTURE A GOOD POUNDING**, poured it out over some woven cloth, and let the water drain away. When it was dry, only the fibers were left behind... and Cai had a sheet of paper! The invention of paper allowed **ideas and knowledge to be spread much faster**.

Paper was made in huge sheets and then cut down to size.



造纸术  
蔡伦